GERMANY

BERLIN. At Berlin, in the city prison called Calands Hoff, there are eight rooms on the ground-floor, and down ten steps eight dungeons: these rooms (thirteen feet by nine feet four inches) were numbered, and had barracks and stoves, one stove for two rooms. The dungeons are for the more atrocious criminals, of whom I saw several in irons, who were chained to staples in the wall. In 1778 the number of prisoners was eighteen men and thirteen women; and in 1781 it was fifty-eight of both sexes. Two of these were debtors; whose allowance is two grosche (3¼d.) a day each. This allowance is paid by the creditors, and if omitted one week, the debtor is set at liberty. The allowance to criminals is one grosche and a half. The prisoners, when their process is finished, are permitted to go into the court; the men for an hour each time, at eight, one, and four in summer, and three in winter; the women for one hour only in the day, from two to three. The prisoner, at his discharge, pays the gaoler a grosche a day, for the time he was confined before his process was finished, unless the judge orders otherwise. The process ought to be finished in three months; and if it is not, the secretary is required to give account of the cause of the delay. After three months' imprisonment, the fee to the gaoler is only half a grosche a day. Here is a head-keeper, who has apartments in the prison; an under-gaoler whose rooms look towards the prison windows; a surgeon whose salary is fifty crowns (écus) a year, besides the pay for his medicines; a chaplain; and a secretary (greffier) who keeps the books, papers, etc. The head-keeper's salary is fifteen crowns and twelve grosche a quarter. In a book which he keeps, the following particulars are entered in ten columns—the time when the prisoner was committed—the magistrate by whom he was committed — his name — age — religion — place of nativity — condition—cause of confinement—time of discharge—and the number of prisoners. One of the judges is obliged to visit the prison once a week.

There were only three or four prisoners in a room, none of whom are permitted to go into the court till their process is finished (as my conductor informed me), that confederates may not be together. One soldier at the gate, guards the prison in the daytime; but at night it is guarded by one within, and another at the back of the prison. These soldiers are relieved every two hours.

There is no torture-room in any of the prisons in the Prussian dominions, for the present king [1] has set the example in Germany of abolishing the cruel practice. In one of the rooms of this prison are alphabetically digested, the names and descriptions, with the sentences, of all who have been confined in this prison, in order that should they be found here a second time, they may suffer a much severer punishment.

In the court-prison (Haus-Voightey), there are seven cells for criminals, and over them eight rooms for debtors and smugglers. These rooms look into a court, to which prisoners have access two hours in a day. All the rooms have barracks and stoves as in the other prison.[2]

The Maison de Travail, is a spacious building in the suburbs: it was erected in 1758: the front is two hundred and twenty feet, the sides a hundred and sixty. It has a court in the centre. The number of inhabitants in 1778, were about four hundred and fifty, including fourteen children, and in 1781 five hundred and forty-six. Beggars, idle persons, and petty offenders of both sexes are sent to this house. Those who can work are employed, fed, and clothed; and proper care and attention paid to the aged and infirm. Every time I was there, I was pleasingly struck with the cleanly appearance of all the inhabitants. Old and young, men and women, were spinning and carding wool, in rooms about seventy-five feet by twenty-four. All have clean linen once a week; and I observed a towel hanging up in each room. The apartments are whitewashed once a year: this gives freshness and neatness, and also light to the workrooms. Here is a chapel with two galleries, one for each sex; and an apartment for the chaplain. The hall for meals is spacious: the hours, seven, twelve, and seven. I was present at dinner-time; after ringing a bell, in ten minutes all were seated at about twenty tables, eighteen to each table. Four separate tables were at a little distance for criminals. A servant having called out, silence, the schoolmaster prayed at the desk in the middle of the room. And after all had helped themselves with barley-soup,[3] while they were eating, he read part of a chapter

[1] Frederick the Great.—[ED.]

[2] Here the criminals had fire in all the stoves, though early in October. On my observing the propriety of this, the gaoler asked me, whether criminals had not fire allowed them in my country? On my saying that in some prisons they had not, he replied, "How then do they exist in winter?"

[3] I tasted the barley-soup, the bread and the beer, which were wholesome and good, and they had enough.—They have butter or cheese, with their bread for supper.